he believed he had nothing more to learn, Nagaraja, king of the snake-spirits, took him to his palace at the bottom of the ocean to show him hitherto unknown sutras, including the *Prajnaparamita Sutra*s, or 'Wisdom Discourses'. After studying them Nagarjuna returned to South India, where the ruling king was a follower of heretical teachings who refused to grant Nagarjuna an audience. Believing that the king had to be converted in order for the dharma to spread, Nagarjuna joined the king's bodyguard and duly became their commander. His name finally reached the ear of the king, who summoned Nagarjuna and asked him who he was, to which the sage replied that he was a man of perfect wisdom. The king then put him to the test, which ended with the king accepting his teaching, along with all the Brahmins in his court, who 'shaved off their tufts of hair and received full ordination'.[9]

The kernel of this tall tale is that Nagarjuna became an adviser to a king of the Satavahana dynasty. Inscriptional evidence from the Amaravati stupa railing points to that king being Yajna Sri Satakarni, believed to have ruled between about 167 and 196 CE, which fits Nagarjuna's presumed dating. There is nothing to show that Yajna Sri Satakarni converted to Buddhism, but he and his successors undoubtedly created a tolerant and peaceful environment in which new ideas could be freely explored and exchanged without fear of giving offence.

It is no exaggeration to state that under these later Satavahanas Buddhism in the South underwent a transformation quite as dramatic as that experienced under Ashoka in Northern India. From the first century CE onwards radical schools of philosophy in Buddhist monastic institutions were established throughout the Krishna River valley and along the coast of what is now Andhra Pradesh, giving rise to a new teaching of Buddhism that came to be known as Madyamaka or the 'Middle Way', which in turn laid